A2

by Moulik Nanda & Sudarsinii Mazumdar

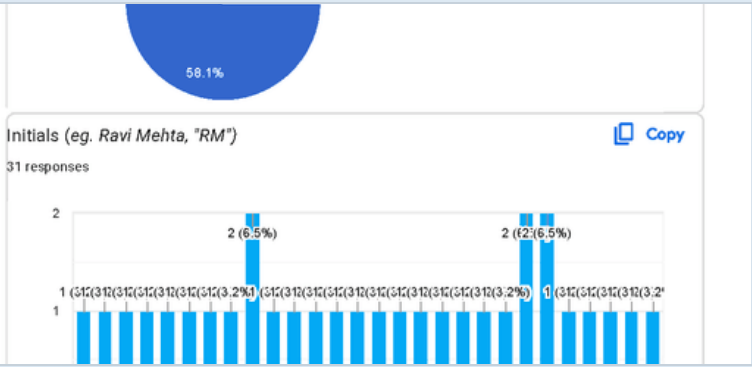
Current State of Funerals

According to the Civil Registration System (CRS) 2023 report released by the Registrar General of India, the country registered approximately 8.66 million deaths in 2023. The vast majority of these fall under Natural Deaths, primarily driven by non-communicable diseases such as ischemic heart disease and stroke, followed by communicable and maternal conditions. Conversely, Unnatural Deaths account for roughly 7% to 10% of the total mortality. These are categorized by the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) as Accidental Deaths & Suicides, which in recent years have included approximately 1.71 lakh suicides 12.3 per lakh population and nearly 4.3 lakh accidental deaths, dominated by traffic accidents, drowning, and accidental falls. Sudden deaths specifically attributed to medical emergencies like heart attacks and brain hemorrhages, which sit at the intersection of natural and sudden causes, also saw a notable 13% increase in the latest records.

A key part of our research was understanding how the unorganized funeral sector currently functions. We approached this with a Subjective Eye, acknowledging that while middlemen are often seen as predatory, they currently provide the only speedy solution available even in comparison to the end to end service (there seemed to be lack of knowledge about such services among people).

We dive deeper into these themes the more we learn and brainstorm from our research.

Survey Responses



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Evolving Traditions_ Urban Funeral Survey.pdf

439.9 KB

Our survey got around 35 responses and hepled us spot some common pain points and patterns with the funeral industry in India. just to note, some of our observations are as follows:-

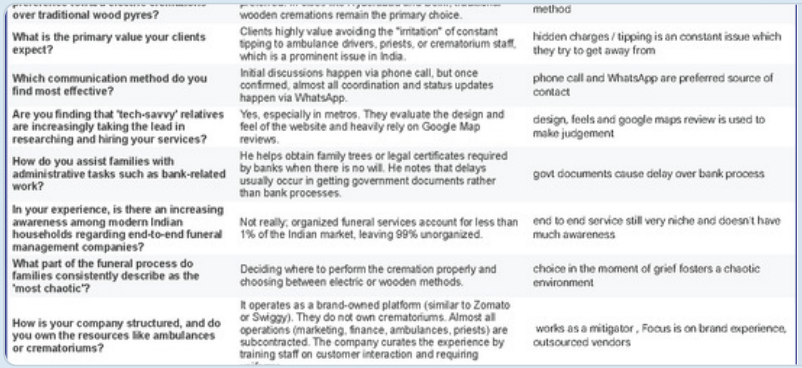
1. Usually the eldest (male) member of the family is the one who plans and budgets a funeral.
2. Currently, most people are unaware/unwilling to work with end-to-end services and middlemen for funeral planning, preferring local community and family networks.
3. Avoiding the stress of coordination and lack of local family support in the city are the leading reasons behind why someone would consider opting for an end-to-end solution.
4. People are still reluctant to involve technology in funeral processes like digitally broadcasting the funeral to distant family members.

Interviews



Family Interview data+ RCA and interventions

87.3 KB



over traditional wood pyres?	wooden cremations remain the primary choice.	method
What is the primary value your clients expect?	Clients highly value avoiding the "irritation" of constant tipping to ambulance drivers, priests, or crematorium staff, which is a prominent issue in India.	hidden charges / tipping is an constant issue which they try to get away from
Which communication method do you find most effective?	Initial discussions happen via phone call, but once confirmed, almost all coordination and status updates happen via WhatsApp.	phone call and WhatsApp are preferred source of contact
Are you finding that 'tech-savvy' relatives are increasingly taking the lead in researching and hiring your services?	Yes, especially in metros. They evaluate the design and feel of the website and heavily rely on Google Map reviews.	design, feels and google maps review is used to make judgement
How do you assist families with administrative tasks such as bank-related work?	He helps obtain family trees or legal certificates required by banks when there is no will. He notes that delays usually occur in getting government documents rather than bank processes.	govt documents cause delay over bank process
In your experience, is there an increasing awareness among modern Indian households regarding end-to-end funeral management companies?	Not really; organized funeral services account for less than 1% of the Indian market, leaving 99% unorganized.	end to end service still very niche and doesn't have much awareness
What part of the funeral process do families consistently describe as the 'most chaotic'?	Deciding where to perform the cremation properly and choosing between electric or wooden methods.	choice in the moment of grief fosters a chaotic environment
How is your company structured, and do you own the resources like ambulances or crematoriums?	It operates as a brand-owned platform (similar to Zomato or Swiggy). They do not own crematoriums. Almost all operations (marketing, finance, ambulances, priests) are subcontracted. The company curates the experience by training staff on customer interaction and requiring	works as a mitigator , Focus is on brand experience, outsourced vendors

End-to-end provider interview

85.2 KB

We interviewed 7 bereaved families, one end-to-end service provider and collected additional data from families outside the Hebbal crematorium. Furthermore, We noted all of the observations we made from these interviews and used them to create a **Meta Matrix** and perform a **root cause analysis** to help **come up with interventions.** You can see how we have colour coded the interview answers with the interventions to showcase our reasoning behind how we came up with these interventions.

Personas

We used our current data and interventions to come up with 3 personas for the bereaving family members.



The traditionalist Kalpan

Primary Decision Maker

Age/Identifying Gender
49/Male

Location
Bangalore, India

Occupation
Bank Manager

Family Status
Wife + 2 kids

"I have to do this right for my father, but everyone is asking for money and I don't know who to trust."

Goals & Motivations

- **Ritual Accuracy:** His primary concern is that traditions are followed perfectly. He feels the weight of social and religious obligation.
- **Cost Control:** He prefers to manage costs personally and is wary of agencies "looting money".
- **Execution:** He coordinates multiple individual vendors (priest, hearse, wood seller) himself.

Pain Points

- **The "Tipping" Culture:** He is stressed by the constant demand for bribes/tips (₹1,000–₹3,000) for "maintenance" or "rituals" at the crematorium, which is a major friction point.
- **Vendor Chaos:** He has to coordinate and pay 5–6 different vendors separately (flower, priest, bamboo bed, etc.), which is physically and mentally exhausting.
- **Administrative Opacity:** He struggles with the death certificate process; if he doesn't have a "family tree" or will, the bank work becomes a nightmare.

Relationship with Tech/Service

- **Low Tech Adoption:** He relies on physical presence and phone calls rather than apps.
- **Resistance to Change:** He is likely to reject an end-to-end agency, preferring "traditional family-managed arrangements".



Modern Coordinator Rahul

The Organiser

Age/Identifying Gender
31/Male

Location
Bangalore, India

Occupation
Product Designer

Family Status
Wife/No kids

"I just want to get this done with dignity and without the chaos. Just tell me the price and handle it."

Goals & Motivations

- **Efficiency & Dignity:** They prioritize saving time and ensuring the process looks respectful and organized over strictly following every minute ritual.
- **Transparency:** They are willing to pay a premium for a "One-Call" guarantee if it means clear costs with no hidden tips or bribes.
- **One Point of Contact:** They prefer dealing with a single professional rather than 10 different vendors.

Pain Points

- **Lack of Local Support:** They often lack a deep local family network to help, making them feel isolated and overwhelmed.
- **The "Chaos" of Handover:** They find the disorganized transition to the furnace and the lack of clarity on ash collection ("left in the dark") highly stressful.
- **Paperwork Delays:** They are frustrated by the weeks it takes to sort out the death certificate and hospital release.

Relationship with Tech/Service

- **High Tech Adoption:** They use Google Reviews to find 5-star services and prefer WhatsApp for status updates.
- **Electric Preference:** They are more likely to choose electric cremation for its speed (1.5 hours vs. 6 hours) and cleanliness.



Grieving Sneha

Immediate Family

Age/Identifying Gender
25/Female

Location
Delhi, India

Occupation
Marketing

Family Status
Lives with parents

"I am in shock. I don't understand what is happening, and the noise is making it worse."

Goals & Motivations

- **Emotional Space:** They want time to deal with their emotions rather than worrying about logistics.
- **Clarity:** They need simple, gentle guidance because they are in a "psychological breakdown" and cannot process complex instructions.
- **Connection:** They are open to digital broadcasts so distant relatives can participate, as they find comfort in shared grieving.

Pain Points

- **Insensitivity:** They are distressed by aggressive relatives ("scream and beat their chest") or insensitive staff who lack sympathy.
- **Information Black Hole:** They feel anxious when they don't know what is happening next; the lack of formal updates is stressful.
- **Waiting:** The long waits for the hearse or for family members to arrive are the most agonizing parts of the day.

Relationship with Tech/Service

- **Passive User:** They may not book the service, but they consume the experience. They appreciate "well-maintained gardens" or peaceful environments to decompress.
- **Need for Support:** They see value in a "professional funeral director" who can act as a buffer between them and the chaos.

Furthermore, we used the data collected from the service providers interviews to come up with another persona for an end to end service provider.



"I view this work as a blessing rather than just a corporate salary. Much like a doctor or tailor, I am remembered for making a difficult situation better for the family."

Pain Points

- **Customer Trust:** People often feel companies are looting money because they do not understand the value of the services and seek the cheapest options.
- **Niche Market:** Organized funeral services account for less than 1% of the Indian market, leaving 99% unorganized.
- **Logistical Bottlenecks:** Delays can still occur in processes where he has little control like getting government documents.
- **Cultural Complexity:** Because perfect organization across 3,000+ communities is difficult, they often use a generalized priests who can perform rituals to satisfy broad requirements.

Hardworking Maddy

End-to-End Service Provider

👨🏽 Age/Identifying Gender
52/Male

📍 Location
Bangalore, India

💼 Occupation
Entrepreneur

🏠 Family Status
Wife+kids

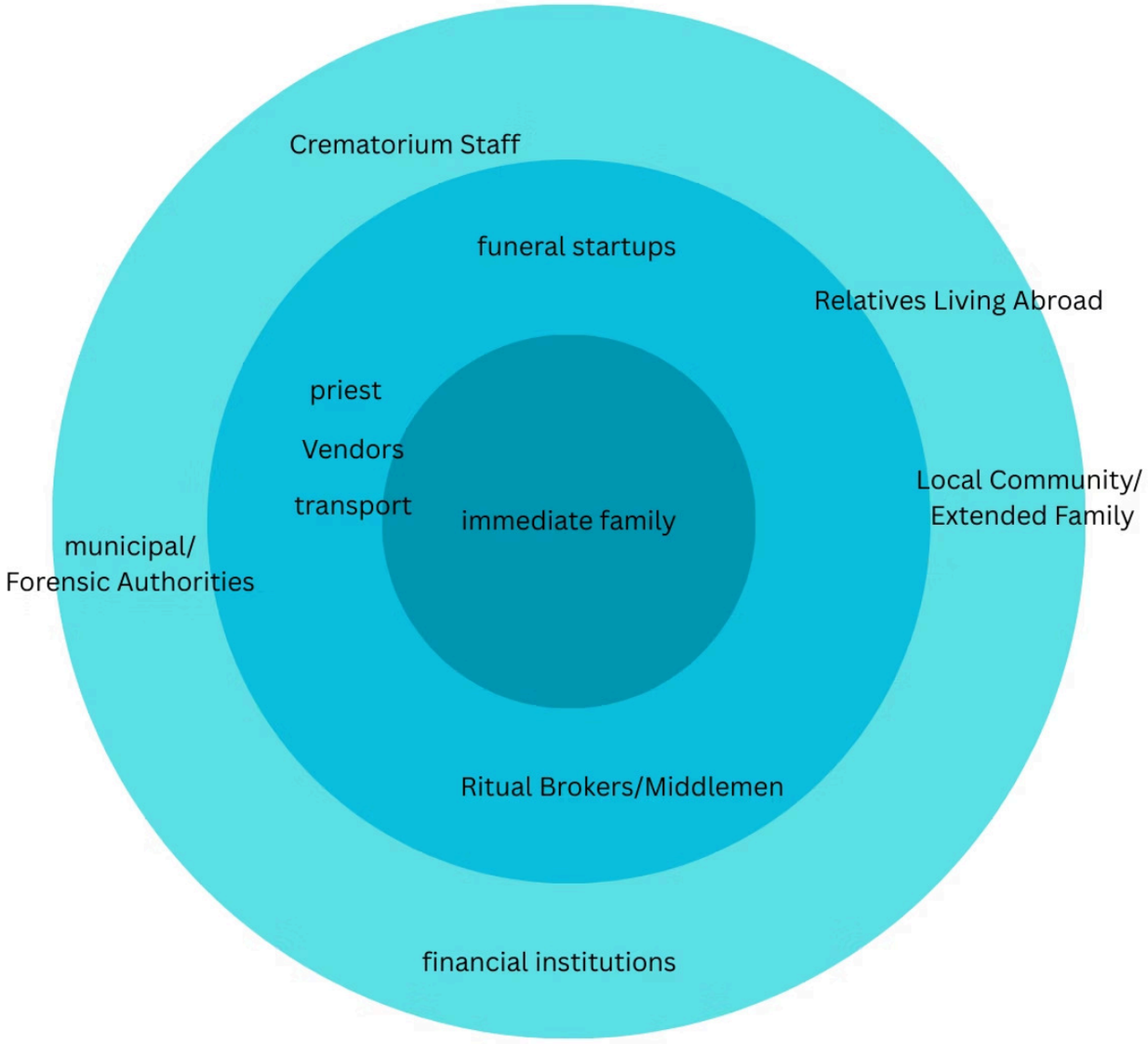
Goals & Motivations

- **Structuring Chaos:** Driven by his experience of losing his father, he wants to provide the organized estate planning and crematorium services he found lacking during his own family crisis.
- **Curated Experience:** He acts as a platform mitigator (similar to Swiggy or Zomato) rather than an asset owner, he subcontracts vendors but tightly controls the brand experience by training vendors and priests on customer interaction.
- **Simplifying Choices:** His goal is to reduce unease by offering fixed packages to simplify the process, ensuring that the customers have to never directly interact with the vendors.

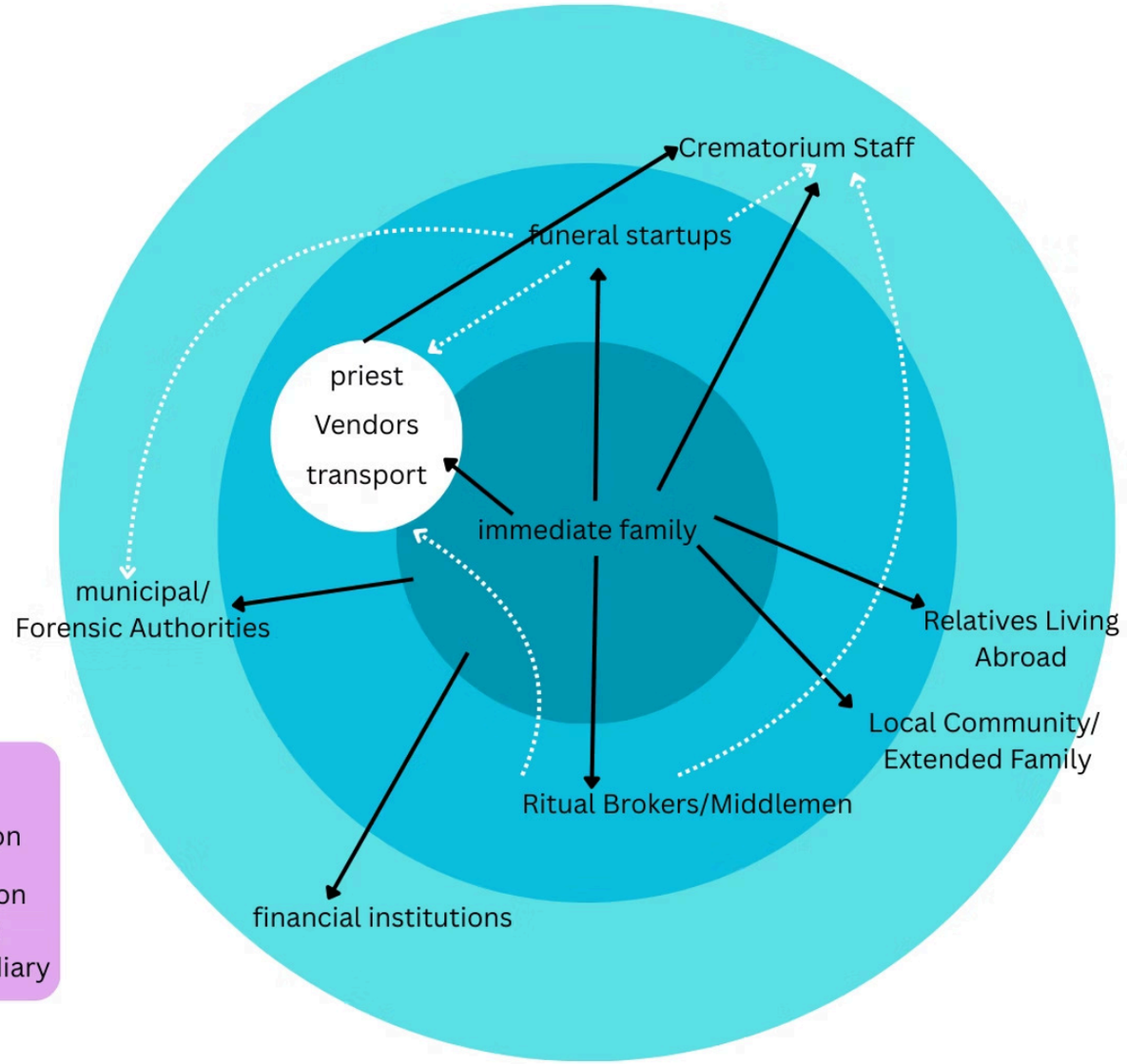
Value Proposition

- **Eliminating Friction:** Clients highly value avoiding the irritation of constantly negotiating with ambulance drivers, priests, or crematorium staff.
- **Guidance:** Families reach out because they simply do not know what to do or where to start. Death is an infrequent event most are inexperienced in handling.
- **Flexibility: T**he provider successfully moderates cases where there are customization that are wanted in the rituals by the clients by coordinating between the family and traditional priests. Any other considerations to provide a smooth procession are seen through by him.

Stakeholder Map



Ecosystem Map



Direct connection

Connection through an intermediary

- **Family ↔ Funeral Startups-** Direct contact to opt for Digital coordination, streamlined planning, and transparent pricing.
- **Family ↔ Ritual Brokers/Middlemen-** direct contact when they need help Navigation of tradition and physical arrangements
- **Family ↔ Priest, vendor, transport-** direct contact when the family opts to do the arrangements on their own
- **Vendors/Transport ↔ Crematorium Staff-** direct contact while coordinating
- **Family ↔ local community -** direct contact for support
- **Priest, vendor, transport ↔ funeral startup/ middleman -** to streamline the arrangements
- **Financial Institutions ↔ Family-** direct contact to deal with financial procedure post death
- **Relatives Abroad ↔ Family-** direct contact to inform and support
- **Municipal/Forensic Authorities ↔ funeral startup -** direct contact for streamline

Customer Journey Map



Customer journey map V1

1.6 MB

In the first version of our customer journey map (blue) we struggled with how to exactly map out a families' experience with 3 separate vendors on a step by step basis which is why we created a separate map (green) that generalized the emotions of the customers based on the gap between the expectations and reality between the services they are getting from each vendor.

While this map intially did the job for us we too our professor's feedback into consideration and expanded the map to also track the emotions of the customer on a per-step basis.

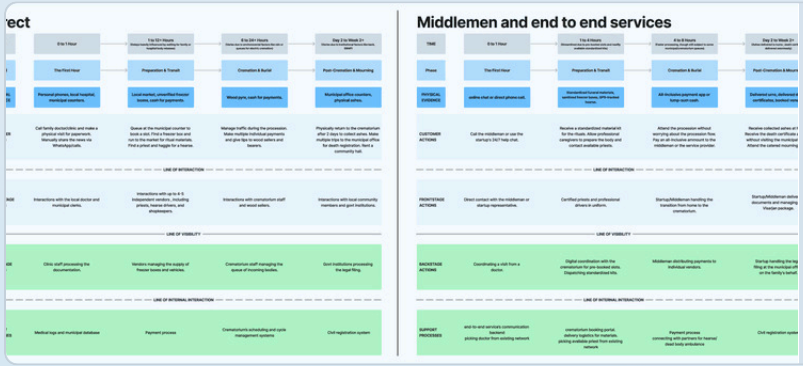


Customer journey map V2

1.6 MB

We were able to achieve this by associating each vendor with a different colour (Direct- Red, Middleman- Yellow, End-to-end startups- Green) and mapping these colours to the one of 5 emotions on the map of our users throughout every single stage of the process.

Service Blueprint



Service blueprint.pdf

1.9 MB

Since the funeral experience for someone directly contacting all vendors is very different from someone who approached an end-to-end company/middleman we created 2 separate blueprints. One for someone who